

TWO GLASSES ON THE PASS

Something shifted after that.

Not dramatically. Not in any way you'd notice if you weren't paying attention. Sam still rode me. Still appeared at my shoulder like some kind of culinary ghost every time my timing slipped. Still called me every name under the sun when my brunoise looked more like rubble than dice.

But there was something else now. Something underneath the bark.

* * *

Sam was an alcoholic.

I say that without judgement—kitchens are full of them, and he was more functional than most. He was also one of the most knowledgeable chefs I've ever worked with. Fish, specifically. The man could talk about species, sourcing, seasonality, and technique like a walking encyclopedia. Ask him about filleting a John Dory and you'd get a twenty-minute lecture you didn't ask for but would never forget.

After the standoff, he decided he was going to teach me about wine.

I didn't drink wine. Didn't drink much of anything, really—except bourbon. Aged bourbon. Neat. None of that cocktail bullshit. Wine was for people who wanted to sound interesting at dinner parties. Or so I thought.

The restaurant was the signature venue of a well-known winery in New Zealand. Which meant the bar was stocked with bottles most people only read about. And every night, after service, Sam would help himself to one.

Never asked. Never logged it. Just walked behind the bar, selected something with the kind of reverence you'd usually reserve for religious artefacts, and poured two glasses.

One for him. One for me.

At first, I was convinced this was just his excuse to polish off a bottle without drawing unwanted attention. Drinking alone looks like a problem. Drinking with a colleague looks like mentoring.

And honestly? The wine was vile.

Every sip tasted like someone had fermented a sock and called it complexity. Sam would swirl his glass, mutter something about "bramble fruit" or "tertiary notes," and I'd nod like I had any fucking idea what he was talking about. The so-called flavour profiles he spoke of were non-existent.

Until they weren't.

I don't know exactly when it happened. Somewhere along the way, things started to shift. The tannins stopped feeling like sandpaper. The acidity stopped making me wince. I'd take a sip and catch something—blackcurrant, maybe, or smoke, or something earthy I couldn't name but recognised.

Sam noticed before I did.

"There it is," he said one night, watching me over the rim of his glass. "You're actually tasting it now."

I didn't respond. But he was right.

Those nights became something I didn't expect. A ritual. The kitchen empty and cooling down, two glasses on the pass, Sam talking about wine or fish or the places he'd worked before he ended up here—not because he had to, but because this kitchen had the kind of product and standards that matched his obsession. He wasn't stuck here. Men like him never are. They just land where the product is worth their attention, and move on when something better calls.

It was a rare window where this life felt somewhat normal. Almost accepting of who I was.

Almost like I belonged somewhere.

* * *

I started looking for a new job a few weeks later.

Chef wasn't kidding when he said it was time to move on. He didn't want me out because I was still the useless dropkick he'd employed three years earlier. He wanted me out because he wanted me to keep the momentum. Standing still in one kitchen too long—even a good one—is how you stall. How you get comfortable. How you stop growing.

So I started looking.

Found a gig in Australia. A resort. Bigger operation, new challenges, a chance to prove that everything I'd learned in New Zealand wasn't just specific to that room.

Turns out Chef knew the resort's executive chef. Old mates from way back. He'd given me a glowing reference.

"Shining" was the word HR used when they called to offer me the position.

Shining. From the man who communicated almost exclusively in grunts and disappointment.

The closest thing *I* ever got to praise from him was three days before I left, middle of prep, when he looked at my bench and said:

"You're gonna need more of your sourdough for dinner service."

That was it.

No "well done." No "you've come a long way." Just an acknowledgement that something I made was good enough that we'd need more of it.

From him, that was everything.

* * *

I left three weeks later.

No fanfare. No speeches. That's not how kitchens work. You hand in your notice, you finish your shifts, you wipe down your section one last time, and you walk out the same door you walked in—except now you're someone different.

Sam didn't say goodbye. Not with words, anyway.

Last service, end of the night, I'm finishing my cleanup and he walks past my station. Doesn't stop. Doesn't look. Just drops a folded piece of paper on my bench and keeps moving.

I opened it later, out in the alley, cigarette in hand.

A reference letter. Handwritten. Two paragraphs. The closest thing to sentiment that man was capable of producing.

I still have it.

Chef shook my hand at the door. Told me not to embarrass him. Told me I was ready—then immediately undercut it by saying I'd probably fuck it up anyway, but that was fine, fucking it up was part of the job.

That was the send-off.

And then I was gone. Off to prove that everything they'd beaten into me actually meant something.

* * *

That was New Zealand. That was where it started.

A lot of kitchens have happened since then. Different cities. Different countries. Different ways of being told I wasn't good enough yet.

More than I can count on one hand. Each one took something and left something behind.

The scars stacked up. So did the lessons.

I think about Sam sometimes. Not often—kitchens don't leave much room for nostalgia—but sometimes.

Usually when I'm watching an apprentice make the same mistakes I made. Reaching for the wrong pan. Letting their temper show. Forgetting that the job isn't just about cooking—it's about staying in the room long enough to become someone worth keeping.